

The proportions of females never married or single in the age group 40-44 may be employed as an index of spinsterhood. It will be noticed that spinsterhood was remarkably stable at the level of 4 to 5 percent right through the period 1946 to 1971 (Table 7.2). Correspondingly the index of bachelorhood too has been fairly stable between 8 to 10 percent during the same period (Table 7.3).

Widowhood and Divorce : The proportion of females widowed at each of the seven five year age segments of the reproductive span has decreased considerably (Table 7.4) during the period 1946 to 1971. A similar trend is observed in the case of widowers too. These trends are consistent with the tremendous advances achieved in mortality reduction during this period.

The proportions of divorced females recorded at the Census of 1946, 1953 and 1963 shown in Table 7.4 do not adequately display the level of marital disruption extent in the country in these years. In 1971 the category "legally separated" was introduced for the first time and a relatively small proportion of the population was included in it. Thus marital breakdown as represented by the proportion of divorced and legally separated women in 1971 seems to reflect only to a very small extent the presumed level of marital disruption. Where the relatively low proportions of divorced males in the age group 30-49 is probably due to the greater opportunities they have for re-marriage.

Regional Variations : The proportionate distribution of currently married and never married women by age group in the four agro-ecological zones mentioned in Chapter III is shown in Table 7.5. It is indeed interesting to note that remarkable differences existed in marital patterns of women in the four zones. (Chart 7.2)

The proportions of currently married women in younger age groups were much less in Zone I than in Zones II and III. In Zone I, the highest proportion 87.0 percent of currently married women was in the age group 35-39 years whereas in Zone II the highest proportion was 91.1 percent in the age group 30-34 years and Zone III it was 90.5 percent in the age group 35-39 years. (Chart 7.2)

7.4 Trends in Fertility

The crude birth rate has been fluctuating erratically between 35 and 42 from the turn of this century until 1959. The crude birth rate in fact started declining steadily commencing from 1960 and reached the level of 34.4 in 1963.

The change in the birth rate during the intercensal period 1946-1953 cannot be analysed in detail in view of the non-availability of births by maternal age prior to 1952. The decline in the birth rate during the intercensal period 1953-1963 has been documented in "Demography"⁴ and in "Monograph"⁵ of the Department of Census and Statistics and was due to changes in the female age structure and female marriage postponement. Marital fertility changed very little during this period. Tables 7.6 and 7.7 show age specific fertility and age specific marital fertility in 1953 and 1963 as well as other fertility indices such as general

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TABLE 7

Age Gro

15-19
20-24
25-29
30-34
35-39
40-44
45-49

TABLE 7

Proport

Proport
Current

1963
1971
% Chang
Never m
1963
1971
% Chang

Current

1963
1971
% Chang
Never m
1963
1971
% Chang

* Wright, N.
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